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# Alcohol … and rehab

**Getting an ultimatum from the Proteas, going through a month of rehab … and emerging on the other side the same, yet different.**

Having read this far – and if you knew anything about me before – it's pretty obvious that alcohol played a big part in my life. There has been a drinking culture in cricket for so long, the game's roots are practically pickled in alcohol. Perhaps this is something that may change over time as the sport becomes increasingly business-orientated, with the sums of money involved growing ever larger and the players' schedules filling up with T20, ODI and Test matches.

My drinking undoubtedly contributed a lot to the fun-filled memories I have, but there were times – particularly between 2006 and 2008 – when it had a very negative effect on me, my career and, most importantly, the people I loved.

I'm not using cricket's drinking culture as an excuse, but that, coupled with my outgoing and fun-loving personality, made refusing a drink practically impossible. And there were many times when I'd be drunk the night before a game, yet the next day be able to deliver an outstanding performance. I've already talked about the evening before the 438 game, and I'll tell you about another occasion as well.

Shaun Pollock's last-ever ODI game at the Wanderers, on 3 February 2008, was also the final match in a five-game series against the West Indies. While we may already have been 4-0 up, I hadn't scored too many runs in those games. Thirty-nine off 52 balls at Kingsmead was as good as it had got for me. You would've thought getting drunk the night before my last